
Your Starter Guide

How to Begin · What to Look For · How to Think

01 Welcome to the Competition

You have registered for “Social Innovation Ideathon” a competition for school students, organised as part of PAN-IIT Andhra Pradesh Summit 2026. Here is what this competition is asking you to do, in simple terms:

- Find a real problem that affects people in a community.
- Understand why that problem exists.
- Propose a practical idea that could help solve it.
- Present your thinking clearly in a PowerPoint presentation.

02 What Is a Social Problem?

A social problem is a problem that affects a group of people — not just one person. It is something that happens in a neighborhood, a town, a city, a district, or a region. It could be about how services work, how people move from place to place, how resources are used, or how systems fail.

Here are some examples to help you understand the difference:

Social problem: Every monsoon, a road near a school gets waterlogged. Students cannot get to class. Autorickshaws refuse to go there. Shopkeepers lose business for weeks.

Social problem: Dustbins in the market area near your home overflow every evening. The waste spills onto the road. Nobody clears it until the next morning. Stray animals tear open the garbage. The smell and mess affect every shop and every person who walks through.

Not a social problem: "My phone battery dies too fast." or "I don't like the food in my school canteen." These are personal preferences. They matter to you, but they are not problems that affect a community.

See the difference? A social problem affects many people. You can see it happening. It has causes that can be understood.

A SOCIAL PROBLEM HAS TWO KEY CHARACTERISTICS

It affects a group of people, not just one person.

It is observable — you can see it, document it.

Start documenting from day one.

Take photographs. Record short videos. Write down what people tell you. Save newspaper clippings or screenshots. This evidence will be the foundation of your presentation.

03 Where Are the Problems?

Now comes the most important part of this competition. Finding a problem.

Don't search for a competition topic.

Search for a real problem.

A problem does not always announce itself. Sometimes, it is something that frustrates people every day. Sometimes, it wastes time, money, or resources. Sometimes, a process works, but could work much better. And sometimes, people become so used to a problem that they stop questioning it.

Your problem can come from anywhere. It could be something you experience every day, something you learn about from a relative in another district, or something you read about in a newspaper. What matters is that the problem is real and that you understand it well enough to explain it clearly, honestly, and with depth.

Here is what to pay attention to:

- Things that repeatedly go wrong and nobody fixes.
- Things people complain about but have accepted as normal.
- Things that waste time, effort, or money — for ordinary people.
- Things that work for some people but leave others behind.
- Things that seem fine on the surface but are broken underneath.

And do not look at the problem only from your own point of view.

Talk to the people around you — parents, grandparents, neighbours, shopkeepers, teachers, auto drivers, farmers, or anyone whose everyday life is different from yours. Ask them how things work. Ask what they find difficult. Ask what they wish could be different. You may be surprised by how much you learn from conversations you have never had before.

The more you listen, the better you will understand the problem. You may realise that your first idea was not the complete picture. You may find that what you thought was the problem is actually something else. Or you may discover a problem that nobody in your team had thought about before.

04 Use the Themes as Lenses

There are nine areas of social life where problems often emerge. These themes are not boxes you have to choose from. They are simply different ways of looking at the world. As you observe, you may find that one situation touches several themes at once. A crowded market, for example, could involve mobility, waste, safety, and livelihoods — all at the same time.

Let the problem lead you. Not the theme.

Traffic & Urban Mobility	Public Health & Hospitals	Water Management & Conservation
Waste Management & Sanitation	Public Safety & Emergency Response	Education & Digital Learning
Climate Resilience & Disaster Preparedness	Agriculture & Farmer Welfare	Governance & Citizen Services

IMPORTANT

If your problem does not fit neatly into any of these nine themes, you are still welcome to pursue it. A strong idea that falls outside these categories will always be valued over a weak idea that fits a theme perfectly.

05 Your Team's Challenge

Now that you understand what a social problem is and how to start looking for one, here is your challenge as a team:

Explore. Observe. Question. Discuss.

Identify situations that deserve a closer look. Talk to people. Pay attention to things you would normally walk past. Take photographs. Write things down. Have conversations you have never had before.

You do not need to find the perfect problem immediately. What matters at this stage is finding something real enough to investigate.

When your team finds something interesting, ask yourselves:

- ? Who is affected by this?
- ? How do we know it is actually happening — not just what we assume?
- ? How often does it happen?
- ? What do people currently do about it?
- ? What might be causing it?
- ? Is there more to this problem than what we can see at first?
- ? Can we learn enough about it to understand it properly?

One thing to remember: the first problem you notice is usually not the full picture. Keep asking "why" until you feel you have reached something deeper — the actual cause, not just the visible symptom.

FOR EXAMPLE

"There is garbage on the street" is what you see. But why is it there? Maybe there are no dustbins nearby. Maybe the collection truck comes only once a week. Maybe residents have no way to report that a bin is full. The real problem is underneath the visible one.

06 What Comes Next

Once your team has found a problem worth investigating, the journey continues.

01

Gather evidence

You will gather evidence that the problem is real — photographs, conversations, data, observations.

02

Analyse the cause

You will analyse why the problem exists — not just what it looks like, but what causes it.

03

Design a solution

You will design a solution — a practical, technology-enabled idea that addresses the root cause.

04

Present your story

You will present everything in a PowerPoint submission that tells the full story.

Detailed guidelines for each of these steps have been shared separately. But none of that matters if you have not found a good problem to begin with.

Right now, you only need to do one thing:

Find a problem worth solving.

Problem Hunt Sheet

Take this with you. Write in it. Think with it.

1 What did I notice?

What is happening? Where did you see it? What caught your attention?

2 Who is affected by this?

Who experiences this problem — directly or indirectly? How does it touch their daily life?

3 What happens because of it?

What difficulties, losses, or risks does this problem create? Think about time, money, effort, safety, or missed opportunities.

4 How do I know this is real?

Have you seen it yourself? Have others told you about it? Does it happen often? Can you show proof?

5 What might be causing it?

Look beyond what you can see. Why does this problem exist? What could be happening underneath?

6 What surprised me?

What did you learn that you did not expect? Did someone give you a completely different way of looking at it?

DOCUMENT EVERYTHING

Take photographs. Record short videos. Write down what people tell you. Save newspaper clippings, screenshots, or any other proof. This evidence will be the foundation of your presentation — without it, your problem is just an opinion.

7 What does our team want to investigate further?

Which problem feels worth understanding better? Why this one?